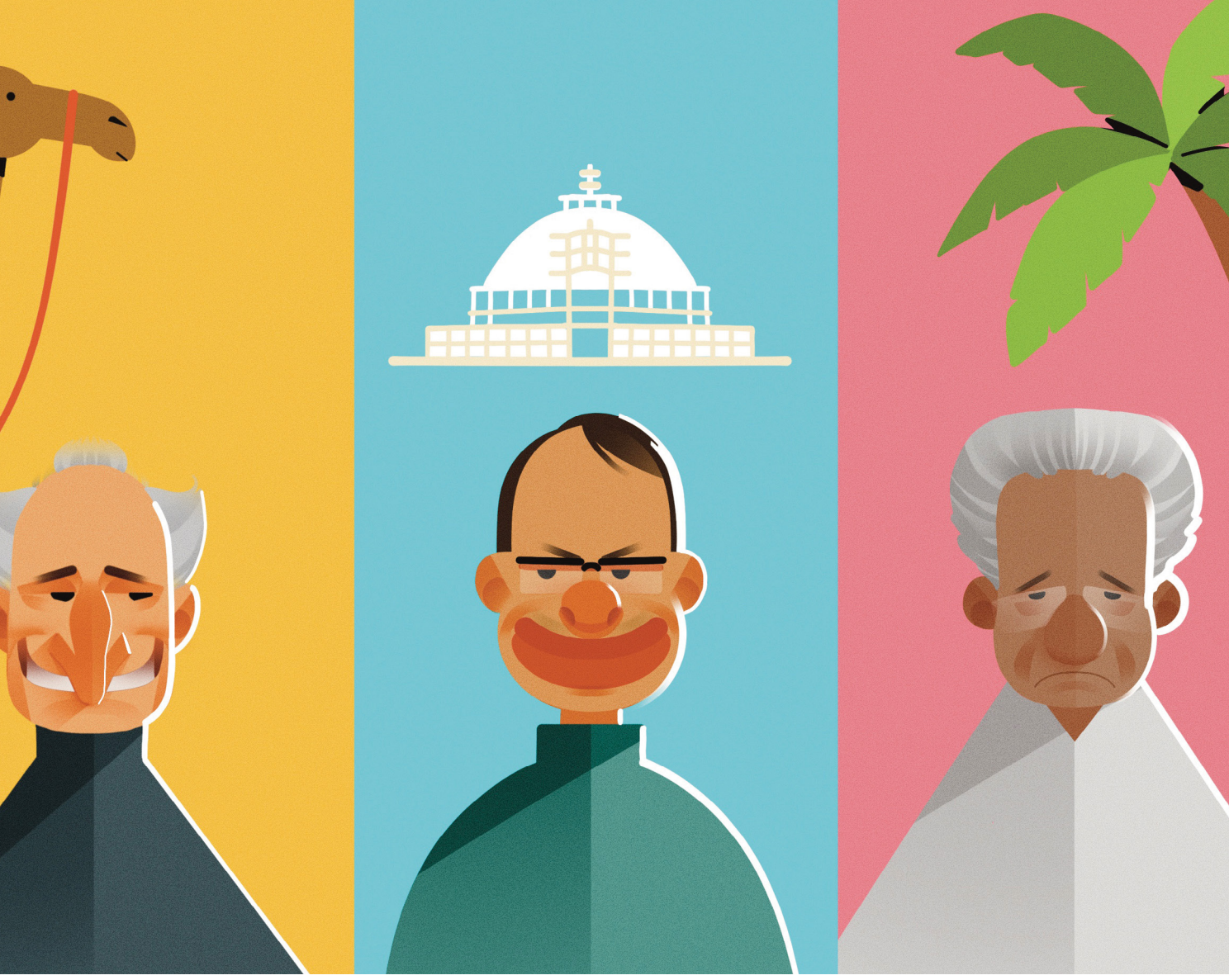


Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

THE LARGESSE

- Women from poor families above the age of 18 to get Rs 1,000 a month under Ladli Behna scheme. Estimated annual outflow: Rs 12,000 crore
- Free residential plots to the poor. Around 36,000 plots already handed over. Cost: Rs 370 crore till now
- Hike in amount of Rs 4,000 annual payout to farmers under CM Kisan Kalyan Yojana

successful CM. He's evidently intent on further strengthening his support base among this demographic. Women account for 48 per cent of the 54 million voters in MP.

A few weeks earlier, Chouhan had announced free residential plots to be parcelled out to the poor. The first lot of plots was distributed in Tikamgarh, covering 10,500 beneficiaries, and later in Singrauli district, this time benefitting 25,000 people. The scheme doesn't involve a payout, and land is indeed a plentiful resource in MP, but the cost of the land has been officially estimated at Rs 120 crore in Tikamgarh and Rs 250 crore in Singrauli.

Top sources in the government say there may be an upward revision in the amount paid as part of the CM Kisan Kalyan Yojana. At present, over 8 million small and marginal farmers get Rs 4,000 each annually, besides the Rs 6,000 paid by the Union government under the PM Kisan Samman Nidhi. The state's amount is released in two instalments. How much the new increment will amount to is not yet known. Official sources foresee some initial hiccups as small and marginal farmers—who make up much bigger numbers than medium and large farmers—will be given the raise before the election.

The Congress had, in the run-up to the 2018 assembly election, announced a farm loan waiver. This was to be done in stages and the party claims it will